

*das Judentum*¹ devotes much space to it, as does Söderblom's great work, *La Vie Future d'après le Mazdéisme*.² How far we may go in recognising Zarathushtra as a real influence among those which ultimately shaped Jewish and Christian eschatology we will inquire later. For the present let us again note merely the similarities and the differences of the two systems, taking first the future of the world and then that of the individual.

Among striking but certainly fortuitous coincidences the most notable concern the figure of the "Future Deliverer." We have seen that *saošyant* in the Gathas is the term which Zarathushtra uses of himself and his immediate followers. He believes that it will be his own work to inaugurate a new era, and he pictures a fiery purging of the world wherein all evil will be destroyed. Moreover, he distinctly implies that "this generation shall not pass away till all these things have happened." The Prophet died, and "all things continue as they were from the beginning of the creation." For us, as in the case of one yet greater than Zarathushtra, the lesson is that to know the *when* of future certainties, discerned by prophetic insight, is for some reason wholly incompatible with the conditions of a real humanity.³ The religion

¹ Haarlem, 1898.

² Paris, 1901.

³ To discuss the application of this principle to the Gospels, under the guidance of Mark 13³², is of course impossible here; nor can I even indicate my own view without trespassing out of my present subject, difficult though it is even to institute a comparison without stating my standpoint in this much-discussed question. To show that I have not ignored the problem, I may just refer to a paper entitled "Maranatha" in the *Free Church Year-book* for 1911, and to *Religions and Religion*, p. 141.

adapted itself, as Christianity had to do, to the postponement of the great hope. Saoshyant became a figure of the distant future linked with Zarathushtra by a miraculous birth.¹ The too dogmatic precision of Magian thought ultimately fixed a date for the coming of Saoshyant. According to the Bundahish, as worked out by E. W. West (*SBE*, xlvii. p. xxxi), his birth will take place in 2341 A.D., his two fore-runners dating respectively one and two thousand years before this: the actual Renovation is fixed for 2398 A.D., when Saoshyant reaches the age of fifty-seven. Parsi prediction, wiser than that which even in our own time gains thousands of credulous adherents in Christendom, left a good margin of time before its assertions could be put to the test of experience. *Qui vivra verra!*

As we saw above, Zarathushtra himself concentrates mainly on the individual's future destiny, and the reaction of that destiny on present conduct. 'That men will be judged at last for all their thoughts, words, and deeds, and that their own Self will determine a future destiny of weal or woe, is the sum of his teaching, and it is the sum of Christian teach-

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ing also. He is equally in accord when he promises the righteous a spiritual Paradise, endless in duration, vocal with songs of praise, and bright with the Presence of God and the Spirits that surround the Throne. Even the imagery of celestial food is common to both systems, while the difference between "spring butter" and "the fruit of the vine" is sufficient to prove the emblems wholly independent. We have seen that Zarathushtra associated Judgement with the old mythological idea of the Bridge over which the soul must pass to heaven, but added to it the significant figure of *Cinvant*, "the Separater": here we are at once reminded of Matt. 25³² (and Joel 3¹⁴?). There was one contingency for which Zarathushtra made provision, the thought of which never came into Old or New Testament. His criterion for the "separation" at the Bridge must have been the ancient balancing of merits and offences, the soul going to heaven or hell according as the one or the other predominated. It was inevitable therefore that the case of equal or nearly equal balance should come into consideration. The Christian system went deeper. Every man must be either wheat or tare, either fig or thistle, and a mixed crop of figs and thistledown is unthinkable. Now of course this seems flatly to contradict the facts of life. We are mixed, very mixed; and Zarathushtra undeniably faced a notorious reality, whatever we may think of his solution of it. The Christian answer would be that diagnosis is so impossible to human faculties that we cannot even imagine an absolutely just award upon any one human record: if we are theists we must assume that an infinitely higher Intelligence

will solve the problem which is too hard for us even to set down. Our more practical problem is to live, and to bring life to others.

And what of Retribution, for those who definitely "chose the Worst Thought"? For the Gathas there seems to be but one answer.¹ Penal suffering without end—ill food and crying of "Woe!"—nothing less is the reiterated threat of the Prophet to those who defy his gospel. The Molten Metal, which accomplishes the "separation" (*vīdāiti*) of mankind at the General Judgement, would naturally be supposed to annihilate either the whole being of the sinner or the evil that is in him. The annihilationist and the universalist theories may emerge in later Parsism, but neither seems to have occurred to Zarathushtra. And of course—explain it how we may—penal suffering without visible end is the figure which in the New Testament sets forth the awful reality and heinousness of sin. Independent witnesses here, most certainly—for the resemblances vanish when we come to detail,—the prophet minds which searched most deeply the realities of life agreed that their consequences must last beyond any limit that our eyes can see.

One point may be mentioned from later Parsism as a

¹ I must correct what I said in *ERPP*, 70, as too strong for the evidence. Prof. Jackson sends me a note here which I am glad to quote:—"My own view has long been that Z. preached eternal (*yavaēca yavaētātaēca*) punishment for the sinners, as implied so often in the Avesta and elsewhere; yet we have in Z. the same problem as with our own Christian 'everlasting.' The Pahlavi interpretation always renders the phrase, so far as I can remember, by 'till the future body' (*tan-i-pasīn*), or 'until the Resurrection' (*rist-ākhēž*)."

good illustration of fortuitous parallel. Böklen (p. 58f.) quotes from the *Sad Dar*¹ a statement that a soul which on the Fourth Night proved to be deficient in good works might have the necessary amount made up by Mithra and Rashnu out of the works of supererogation accumulated by men of the good religion.² In later Judaism and medieval Christianity this doctrine makes its appearance, and as far as date goes the Parsi writer might be a borrower. But it comes very naturally out of the idea of weighing merits, which is fundamental in Persian thought. The *Sad Dar* theologian insists upon that doctrine on the very next page, urging that, if the sin outweighs the merit by the estimation of a hair, that person arrives in hell. He does not seem to remember the other statement, which would require us to believe that the treasury of supererogatory good works was empty. The oversight is due simply to the fact that the writer has a different object. When he tells of the works of supererogation, he is insisting that men must have no "hesitation and doubt" as to the superiority of the Religion to all other faiths, with its store of superfluous merits for the steadfast believer to draw on. His moral in the next chapter is that "even if a sin is trifling it is not desirable to commit it." If this conception should after all be old, there is no plausible reason for supposing that the Rabbis knew of it, and as little for the converse: we have only independent deductions from rather similar premisses.

¹ *SBE*, xxiv, 258: on its date see West's introduction, p. xxxvii.

² "This is to be associated," Prof. Jackson writes, "with the prayers for the soul as still made among the Parsis after the death of one beloved."

The weighing of actions is a much older example of independent coincidence. Prof. Jackson¹ cites a passage from the *Çatapatha Brāhmaṇa* to show that this is "an Indian as well as an Iranian idea." This need not mean that we assign it to Aryan antiquity, though it seems to be suggested in the Gathas and is therefore very old in Iran. But some of the Old Testament parallels cited by Böklen are sheltered from suspicion of Zoroastrian influence by their very date: this must at least be true of Job 31⁶, Prov. 16², 21², 24¹². In 1 Sam. 2³ we have the same word applied to the weighing of actions, in a much older passage. But the Hebrew word seems nearer to measuring than weighing.² It is in any case a casual figure which could occur to any writer without help from a foreign literature. The really noteworthy resemblances come much later. Böklen cites the *Testament of Abraham*, which Dr M. R. James assigns to the second century A.D.³ Here we have an angel with scales, and the case of a soul whose sins and merits balance exactly, the total of each having been entered in a book. This would suit a Parsi writing very well indeed, but even here we ought to be able to support the parallel with other suggestions of borrowing before we can be sure of a real connexion.

Before I pass to the formal discussion of the problem of historical dependence, I may collect a few examples of isolated thoughts which resemble one

¹ *Actes du X. Congrès internat. des Orientalistes* (Geneva, 1894), ii. 65 ff.

² See Driver's note on 1 Sam., *l.c.*, and the *Oxford Hebrew Lexicon*, p. 1067.

³ *Texts and Studies*, II. ii. 29: the passage is on p. 90 f.—see also p. 70.

another. I take the Parsi parallel from Pahlavi books, the date of which of course makes borrowing from Christian Scriptures abundantly possible. Nevertheless, I greatly doubt whether this has really taken place: accidental coincidence seems to me far more likely. The Golden Rule in its negative form stands in a position by itself. I have put it into my conjectural restoration of the story underlying *Tobit* (p. 386), because it is found in Parsi writing and may be old: its appearance in *Tobit* may therefore be due to the very special conditions of that book. In the *Bundahish* (*SBE*, v.) we read several sentences to which Biblical parallels occur. Thus (p. 114) the darkness of hell is "fit to grasp with the hand": cf. *Exod.* 10²¹. Of the future life it is said (p. 126 f.):

They give every one his wife, and show him his children with his wife; so they act as now in the world, but there is no begetting of children.¹

There is a certain resemblance to *Luke* 20³⁵ f. A striking passage on p. 124 tells us that a righteous man who did not warn his wicked friend would suffer shame in the assembly of judgement: West quotes a parallel from *Ardâ-Vîraf*, where it is a husband who neglected to teach his wife. We may compare *Ezek.* 33¹⁻⁹.² A distant echo of *Matt.* 25⁴⁰ may be found in the *Dînkart* (*SBE*, xxxvii. 196), where we read:

¹ On this see Söderblom, *La Vie Future*, 269.

² I cannot see that there is any real resemblance between *2 Cor.* 5¹ and *Bd* 30² (*SBE*, v. 127): it is at most a similarity of phrase. It would be more to the point to illustrate Paul here by the Robe in the "Hymn of the Soul," noting that Bardaisan had Parsi affinities.

Whoever gives anything to the disciples of Zaratûšt, his reward and recompense are just as though the thing had been given by him to Zaratûšt.

From the same book (p. 266) we may quote for its resemblance to many Biblical passages,

Let no one practise ill-perpetrated deeds, even though in a wilderness when far from publicity, nor in distress, O Spîtâmân! because Aûharmazd, the observer of everything, is aware of them.

In the *Bahman. Yašt* (*SBE*, v. 197) we have something like the story of Dives and Lazarus:

I have seen a celebrity with much wealth, whose soul, infamous in the body, was hungry and jaundiced and in hell, and he did not seem to me exalted; and I saw a beggar with no wealth and helpless, and his soul was thriving in paradise, and he seemed to me exalted.

And in the same book (p. 203) there is a closer parallel with Micah 7⁶ (Matt. 10³⁶ f.):

And at that time, O Zaratûšt the Spîtâmân! all men will become deceivers, great friends will become of different parties, and respect, affection, hope, and regard for the soul will depart from the world; the affection of the father will depart from the son; and that of the brother from his brother; the son-in-law will become a beggar from his father-in-law, and the mother will be parted and estranged from the daughter.

It will be allowed that these parallels have not much of a moral either way, but they are perhaps sufficiently interesting to warrant quoting. There are doubtless others to be found for the trouble of searching: we must turn to more important matters.

I think I may claim to have presented a sufficient amount of manifestly fortuitous coincidence to justify

an attitude of great caution when dependence is alleged. The need of caution is the more obvious to us when we notice how far-reaching are the theories which have been built on the assumption of this dependence. It is perhaps as well to remember that these theories do not come from Iranian experts, but from scholars whose fame was achieved in other fields. Were we to count only the Iranists, we should even doubt whether the Parsi did not borrow from the Jew, for that was the view of Darmesteter! And it must be allowed that, however high is the authority of the protagonists in this controversy, they have nearly all come to the problem from another side, compelled to take much at second hand when dealing with Iranian texts. The real Avestan experts are very cautious indeed. From yet another point of view we learn the same lesson. Nothing impresses us more vividly, in prolonged reading of modern *religionsgeschichtlich* research, than the tenuity of the resemblances upon which historical connexion is often built up. Böklen's parallels are to a very large extent a conspicuous example in our particular field, though they are vitiated still more seriously by indifference to the date of his Parsi authorities, and to the existence—often naïvely admitted—of equally impressive parallels from other sources. The very thought of fortuitous coincidence seems hardly to enter the minds of many most learned and acute investigators.¹ The cautions of Prof. Clemen, in his

¹ I cannot resist quoting one extraordinary example touching the other side of the Aryan field. Dr Hugo Gressmann, in his most able and suggestive book on the origin of Jewish eschatology (p. 305), finds traces of mythus in the statement (Isai. 41⁸) that

introduction to *Primitive Christianity and its Non-Jewish Sources*, are very sane and very much needed, as is best shown by the multitude of comparisons alleged by first-rate scholars which he rejects. But even among those which he accepts, in a thoroughly tentative way, there are certainly some that are very doubtful. The new method needs much more testing before it will give us assured results.

Before we can begin to examine alleged parallels between Judaism and Parsism, we must obviously ask when and how contacts were made. That the Northern Israelites were deported partly to Media clearly cannot help us: later Judaism owed nothing to the Ten Tribes, whose religious apostasy caused them to vanish out of the history of Israel. What of the Jews in the Babylonian Exile? This question concerns the extent to which they had any real Zoroastrianism around them. During the "Persian period," from the reign of Darius down to the fall of the Achæmenian house, the Jews in Palestine were subject to Zoroastrian kings, as we see elsewhere. The period that follows is very dark. The Arsacide dynasty probably helped Greek influence in Judæa; and our knowledge of the conditions is so limited that we can neither form conclusions of our own nor reject on positive evidence any conjectures that ingenious speculation may attempt. What hap-

Cyrus "trod not the path with his feet"—so he translates, with a reference to Dan. 8⁵. It is to be regarded as a trait of divinity, established as such by the passage in the *Tale of Nala*, familiar to every beginner in Sanskrit, where the four gods at Damayanti's prayer distinguish themselves from their human rival by five tests of which this is one. Possibly Gressmann only means it for illustration.

pened during the Sassanian age does not concern us. I should, however, remind those who read detailed comparisons in the work of Bousset or Böklen that the antiquity of material to be found in the Pahlavi books is subject to the greatest uncertainty. We may be dealing with faithfully produced translations of old Avestan texts now lost, or with doctrines of medieval post-Sassanian Parsism. When we add to this the problems of date presented by the material collected in the Talmud, it is clear that the question of interlacing dependence is likely to be often insoluble. Happily, I am able to pass it by, and go back to Babylon as the place of contact, according to Bousset, the most important champion of the theory of Iranian influence on Judaism. It may be well to quote his summary (*Judentum*, p. 548):

The place where Parsism and Judaism came in contact was Babylon and the Babylonian plain. In Babylon, as we have said, was the centre of Jewish religion after the Exile. And there are many indications that on the other side Iranian religion had overflowed its ancient bounds and pushed its way far into the west, and in any case had attained the predominance in the old Babylonian mother-country. When Alexander the Great made his expedition to Babylon, there met him in the front rank the "Magi" or Persian priests, and in the second the Chaldæans, the priests of the Babylonian religion.¹ In Greek tradition

¹ Bousset quotes Quintus Curtius, who gives us the order of the procession which met Alexander when he entered Babylon after Arbela. After the captain of the citadel and the presents he brought came the Magi:—Magi deinde suo more carmen canentes, post hos Chaldaei Babyloniorumque non vates modo, sed etiam artifices cum fidibus sui generis ibant, laudes hi regum canere soliti, Chaldaei siderum motus et statas vices temporum ostendere. So

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